

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

MAHIPAL SINGH, 21

Jaipur, Rajasthan

'No future in Agniveer'

Mahipal Singh, son of a head constable of Rajasthan Police, always wanted to be in the armed forces. So after he passed out of school, he attempted the National Defence Academy officers' training school test four times but did not succeed as he was not good at maths. But he did not lose hope, finally applying for the airmen post in January 2020. He started focussing on his physical fitness, even joined a training academy in Jaipur, for which he spent close to Rs 2 lakh. After going through the entire selection process, which lasted over a year, his name finally appeared on the merit list in May 2021. But the third wave of Covid delayed the next stage. The IAF kept giving administrative reasons for withholding the final result before the sudden announcement of the Agnipath scheme. Mahipal now says the air force cheated him by giving false assurances. He also does not want to join the Agniveers for he fears that after four years he will have no future career. "I have no intention of applying as an Agniveer, as the service does not give you any assurance about your future. I will most likely have to retire at 26 and in four years of service I don't think I will gain any professional skill that will be able to help me in the future," he says.

cess for the air force would be issued call letters soon. But, instead, they brought the Agnipath scheme. I am going to take up the issue in Parliament," says Beniwal. Rajasthan goes to the polls next year and the issue could become a political hot potato for the opposition BJP.

Covid-19 halted the Indian Army's recruitment for over two years. In 2019-2020, the army recruited 80,572 jawans, but there have been none since then. This has left 46 regimental training centres with no fresh batches. On the other hand, the navy and air force have both recruited in the last two years—8,269 and over 13,000 personnel, respectively. Now, the matter is with the apex court, which puts the ministry of defence in a fix. If the court takes a different view, it could turn out to be embarrassing for the government.

The Agnipath scheme, especially its feature that 75 per cent of the recruits will serve only for four years and will not enjoy benefits like regular soldiers, has sparked protests in different parts of the country amid hectic efforts by the central government to assuage the youth's concerns. However, the government has asserted that the scheme will be implemented and that there is no question of a rollback.

"The candidates may have gone through the selection process, but a final merit list was not prepared. Now they can only come in through the Agnipath scheme"

Lt Gen. Anil Puri
Additional secretary, Dept of military affairs

While some experts argue that the professional skills of combat soldiers are enhanced with their years of service and training, the Agnipath scheme proposes a reduced training module. Instead of 2-3 years, now the soldiers will be trained for six months. While there is widespread agreement that the Agnipath scheme will cut costs and improve the age profile of the military, experts worry that it could affect the fighting skill and spirit of the forces. "The reduced training period should not impact the combat effectiveness of the units. On-the-job training is also required. The army job is risk-averse. I doubt whether a person with just four years of service would give his life for the nation," says Lt Gen. Vinod Bhatia, former director-general of military operations. ■